Journal of Sport Management, 2025, 39, 163-179
https://doi.org/10.1123/jsm.2024-0171
© 2025 Human Kinetics, Inc.

Human Kinetics
ARTICLE

Identity Conflict Among Politically Engaged Sport Fans: Implications for Fan Loyalty

Ben Larkin
Sport Management Department, Girard School of Business, Merrimack College, North Andover, MA, USA

Despite the natural intersection of sport and politics, it remains an understudied topic in academic literature. Further, the majority of scholarship in this area is either rooted in sport sociology, or, aimed at advancing the political science literature. Few studies have looked at the intersection of sport and politics for the purpose of advancing sport marketing scholarship. This is the case in spite of the fact that consumers increasingly expect businesses to take political stands. The current study begins to fill this void by examining the impact of political identity conflict on sport fan loyalty. Across two studies, results indicate that political identity conflict negatively affects attitudinal loyalty, but not behavioral loyalty. Furthermore, differences between liberal and conservative sports fans as it pertains to managing political identity conflict and their perceptions of the intersection of sport and politics are explored. Implications for theory and practice are discussed.

***Keywords**:* consumer behavior, consumer psychology, identification

"Republicans buy sneakers, too." — Michael Jordan.

The above quote from basketball great Michael Jordan summarizes the notion that businesses should shy away from divisive political issues, lest they risk alienating consumers. Such was the prevailing business logic for decades, but the perspective began to shift with the rise of corporate social responsibility in the 1980s and has only continued with the advent of the 24-hr news cycle (Bailey & Phillips, 2020). Today, brands feel increasing pressure to take political stands (Zahn, 2022).

Scholars have studied how a consumer's political identity might impact their consumption behavior. In some studies, consumers have been found to behave in ways consistent with their political identity (Hoewe & Hatemi, 2017; Jung & Mittal, 2020). In other studies, however, scholars have found that consumers are not swayed by corporate political advocacy (Bailey & Phillips, 2020). Gift and Miner (2017) detailed the many ways sports and politics intersect, arguing that, despite the overlap of these fields, research integrating the two remains sparse. What's more, the few studies that have been conducted on this subject have focused primarily on implications for the political sphere (e.g., Eschmann et al., 2021; Serazio & Thorson, 2020). Given the modern political climate—an environment characterized by partisan polarization and the omnipresence of divisive political discourse on media outlets worldwide—this is problematic; firms must understand how their political interventions affect consumers. While there seemingly is little downside in taking a political stance vis-à-vis consumers who support the position being taken, it is less clear how the elicitation of identity *conflict* could affect consumption behavior.

According to Mansfield et al. (2022), identity conflict occurs when two salient identities are perceived as incompatible. For example, in 2020, the National Basketball Association (NBA) integrated progressive politics into its core product, allowing players to replace the name on their jersey with a phrase representing a relevant social issue. For fans with more conservative beliefs, identity conflict could emerge—they could feel torn between their political orientation and their NBA fandom. In fact, this is precisely what happened with legendary NBA coach Phil Jackson. The retired coach indicated he no longer watches the NBA, remarking that the league was "trying to cater to an audience . . . and they didn't know it was turning other people off" (Sforza, 2023, para. 5). This begs the question: How widespread is the perspective espoused by Jackson? Does political identity conflict have the potential to compromise the loyalty of sport fans?

Fan loyalty can be understood as the "strength of a relationship between an individual's relative attitude and repurchase behavior" (Karjaluoto et al., 2016, p. 52). In that sense, there is both an attitudinal and behavioral component. Sometimes these constructs are studied independently. At other times, a composite measure is used, wherein elements of both are combined into a single measure. Consumer loyalty has been shown to be associated with a number of desirable outcomes for sport organizations. These range from greater sales and profits (Tsiotsou, 2013) to reduced price sensitivity (Bae et al., 2021) and favorable word-of-mouth (Casidy & Wymer, 2015). Because of such desirable outcomes, fan loyalty has been an index of interest in both practice-oriented research (e.g., Plunkett Research, 2013; PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011), as well as academic literature (e.g., Bae et al., 2021; Tsiotsou, 2013). The current research extends this focus, drawing in a phenomenon of escalating importance given unprecedented levels of political engagement and polarization globally.

Despite its omnipresence, the impact of political advocacy in a sporting context has not been extensively studied. When it has, the focus has remained primarily on political outcomes. Thus, it is not well understood how this impacts the loyalty of sport fans, particularly when political identity conflict occurs. Therefore, this study is exploratory in nature and comes with the purpose of better understanding how political identity conflict affects sport fans.

Research integrating sport, politics, and consumer behavior, as well as two theories germane to sport fandom, Heere and James's (2007) work on external identities, and Heider's (1957) balance theory were used to inform the study. To explore the research questions (RQs), a mixed-method study was conducted. The topic

Address author correspondence to larkinb@merrimack.edu, https://orcid.org/0000-0001-6832-1001

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

is critically important given the potential for political advocacy to negatively impact brands. In the summer of 2023, Anheuser-Busch featured transgender influencer Dylan Mulvaney in a social media marketing campaign for their Bud Light product, sparking outrage from conservative consumers. A Bud Light boycott ensued, causing revenue in the July–September earnings period to plummet by 13.5% (The Associated Press, 2023). Therefore, in addition to providing a strong foundation for the study of political identity conflict and sport fandom, the current study also comes with crucial insights for sport organizations seeking to navigate the choppy waters of a divisive political climate.

Literature Review

Sport and Politics

Sports and politics have long intersected. Tracing all the way back to ancient Greece (Golden, 1998), this relationship now manifests in forms ranging from the Olympic Games being used as a platform for geopolitical theater and one-upmanship to former athletes and/or coaches running for public office, athletes using their platform for political statements, and much more. Indeed, sport is inherently political, and yet the relationship between sport and politics remains a criminally understudied area in academic scholarship (Gift & Miner, 2017). Gift and Miner (2017) sought to address this apparent oversight by laying out an agenda for research on this subject matter. In doing so, they noted that the vast majority of research on sport and politics could be described as historical and/or sociological, irrelevant to electoral politics, and devoid of rigorous quantitative analysis.

Indeed, much of the work in the sport management discipline has been published in sport sociological journals (e.g., Allison, 1982; Boykoff & Carrington, 2020; Dart, 2014; Evans et al., 2020; Long & Hylton, 2002). In recent years, the focus of much of this work has been on gaining a better understanding of racial injustice through examining the context of sport. Many of these studies used former NFL quarterback Colin Kaepernick's protest of racial injustice and police brutality in 2016 as a context through which to frame their analyses. For example, Boykoff and Carrington (2020) conducted a content analysis of newspaper coverage of this story between 2016 and 2018, investigating the impact it had on the discussion of racial inequality and police brutality against African Americans in the United States. Serazio and Thorson (2020) also investigated the Kaepernick incident, capturing sport fans' disdain for the politicization of sport and reaffirmation of long-held stereotypes of Black athletes. Evans et al. (2020) looked at the intersection of sport, race, and ethnicity more broadly, using the analysis to highlight key questions pertinent to the modern political climate—the intensity of which seemed to escalate in the years following Kaepernick's protest. In this same spirit, Agyemang et al. (2020) examined the capability of athlete activism of this nature in shaping public policy.

In reviewing the literature in this area, it is apparent that another stream of literature on the intersection of sport and politics—Gift and Miner's (2017) work included—could be construed as using the sport context with the aim of advancing the political science discipline (Dichter, 2021; Towler et al., 2020). Kaepernick's protest was used as a context of study in this area as well. For example, Towler et al. (2020) investigated the impact of Kaepernick's protest on political mobilization, specifically examining the extent to which activism of this nature can inspire African Americans to take political action.

A few studies have looked at the behavior of sport fans in a political context, but did not aim to explore consumer implications. Eschmann et al. (2021) used the context of Kaepernick's protest to examine social media users' proclivity to consider alternative points of view. Dart (2014) addressed how new media technology is changing the production, delivery, and consumption of sport content. In doing so, he considered consumption behavior not from a marketing standpoint, but rather from a political economic perspective, exploring issues, such as ownership, structure, production, and delivery, ultimately concluding that the proliferation of these technologies in sport represents the perpetuation of existing neoliberal capitalist tendencies of sport organizations.

It appears that only three studies have addressed the impact of political advocacy on sport consumer behavior (e.g., Kim et al., 2020; Mudrick et al., 2019; Thorson & Serazio, 2018), but each comes with limitations at it pertains to the aim of the current study. Kim et al. (2020) investigated consumers' perceptions of the motives behind Nike's use of Colin Kaepernick in their advertising, and how this impacted their attitudes, and behavioral intentions, toward the brand. They ultimately found that if perceived as altruistic, or based on the company's true core values, brand attitudes and positive word-of-mouth intentions increased. However, if perceived as ego- or image-driven, less favorable attitudes and negative word-of-mouth intentions ensued. This research was a valuable step forward for the discipline, but two things about this study highlight the need for the current research. First, the focal context of the study was Nike—an athletic apparel brand. While relevant to sport, there are vast differences between consumer product brands like Nike and entities, such as sport teams, leagues, and athletes vis-à-vis consumer identification, and loyalty (Fujak et al., 2018; Manoli, 2024). Second, participants' political orientation and/or degree of identity conflict was not captured in this study. Thorson and Serazio (2018) did capture political orientation in their work, finding conservative fans to be more likely to bristle at the perceived intrusion of politics into sport, but no insight into psychological and/or behavioral outcomes was provided.

Mudrick et al. (2019) explored athlete political advocacy in a spectator sport context, collecting data that provide some insight on both participants' political orientation, as well as attitudes and behavior toward the athlete and their team. However, their study, while an interesting first step, was designed in such a way that presents validity concerns. Participants they recruited from Amazon's Mechanical Turk were assigned to one of four conditions in a pre/post quasi-experimental design. They were asked to respond to items measuring their level of identification, attitudes toward, and present consumer behavior related to a favorite sport team. They were then asked to think of a player they like on that team and answer a similar set of attitude and behavior questions in relation to the player. Subsequently, they were asked to think of a U.S. president they either have, or have not, supported (depending on their condition) and respond to a set of items measuring their identification with that president. Finally, participants were asked to imagine that the player wrote an op-ed about the president and were subsequently provided with a fictitious op-ed from a newspaper that expressed either support or criticism (again, depending on their condition) toward the president they identified. They were then asked to respond to the same attitude and behavior questions from the pretest—this time with consideration given to the hypothetical remarks. The difference between the pre- and posttest on these measures served as the outcome variable in the study.

Where validity could be questioned is with respect to the procedure. Participants were asked to answer the posttest questions

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

based on a hypothetical scenario that they knew did not actually occur. They were essentially being asked to evaluate these items based on how they imagine they would feel, which could be difficult to do accurately. The scope of the study is also limited to support, or lack thereof, for a U.S. President. This is one potential area where political identity conflict may be likely to occur, but there is a wide spectrum of potential sources—from athlete activism for a particular social issue to marketing activities that imply support for a particular cause, the remarks, or actions of an athlete, or team representative that express or exhibit a particular point of view, and more.

As a result, only so much is understood with respect to how political advocacy and identity conflict affects consumer outcomes in the context of spectator sport. This is precisely what the current study aims to address. Research toward this end *has* been conducted in the mainstream marketing discipline. Attention shifts toward this literature stream in the subsequent section.

Politics and Consumer Behavior

It is well established in the literature that an individual's political beliefs have a pronounced impact on their attitudes, opinions, and behaviors (Jost, 2017; Jung et al., 2017; Jung & Mittal, 2020). Jost (2017) detailed how variables, such as cognitive processing style, and personal values, factors central to consumer decision-making processes (Jung & Mittal, 2020) are relevant to and, indeed, shaped by, one's political orientation. It is not surprising, then, that political orientation has been shown to be relevant to everything from consumer complaints (Jung et al., 2017) to consumer resistance (Ulver & Laurell, 2020). The impact of corporate political advocacy on consumers' attitudes and purchase decisions has been one particularly strong area of focus for marketing scholars in recent years (Bailey & Phillips, 2020; Haupt et al., 2023; Hoewe & Hatemi, 2017; Jung & Mittal, 2020).

The lion's share of research in this area highlights the impact of corporate political advocacy on consumer behavior, showing that people tend to favor firms who operate in ways that are consistent with their political beliefs (Haupt et al., 2023; Hoewe & Hatemi, 2017; Jung & Mittal, 2020). Haupt et al. (2023) found that when brands take political stands, consumers who disagree with their stance feel marginalized and tend to form more negative attitudes toward the brand as a result. Hoewe and Hatemi (2017) showed that this has the power to impact brand loyalty. Using a design that measures participants' actual behavior, the scholars showed that when a Coca-Cola advertisement featuring Muslim and Arab individuals was shown to conservative participants, they responded by selecting Pepsi products. In contrast, liberal participants exhibited an enduring loyalty to Coca-Cola.

While the literature has been fairly consistent in demonstrating an impact of corporate political advocacy on consumer attitudes and behavior, Bailey and Phillips (2020) argued that this may be overstated. The researchers presented consumers who possessed a wide range of political beliefs with a description of a fictious company. All participants received the same baseline information on the company, but some were told that the company was very conservative and others were told the company was quite liberal. Among the findings was that the opinion of those who identified as Republicans was unaffected by whether the company was said to possess a conservative or liberal agenda. Democrats were unaffected by the report that the company was liberal, but their opinion of the company was considerably more negative when it was reported that it had conservative values. In sum, it is clear that, to varying degrees, corporate political stances have *some* impact on attitudes and behavior toward the company in question. It is worth noting, however, that the passion and loyalty exhibited by sport fans has long been considered to be a unique factor that distinguishes this group from consumers of traditional, mainstream businesses (Fujak et al., 2018; Manoli, 2024; Smith & Stewart, 2010). Given the idiosyncratic nature of consumer loyalty in a sport context, and its pertinence to the current study, it is worth delving a bit deeper into this construct.

Sport Fan Loyalty

Mahmoudian et al. (2021) defined fan loyalty as a relationship with a sport entity that results in a positive attitude and enduring behavioral commitment to said entity. Indeed, the construct is typically conceptualized as possessing at least two related dimensions, an attitudinal and a behavioral dimension. In some cases, researchers conceptualize consumer loyalty as a four-stage construct (i.e., cognitive, affective, conative, and action/behavior; e.g., Han et al., 2011). Even in such cases, the early stages of the model can be understood as attitudinal in nature, while the later stages speak more to behavioral commitment.

The attitudinal component can be understood as an attitude toward an entity that is persistent and resistant to change, serving as a compass for one's behavior (Funk & James, 2001; Heere & Dickson, 2008). The theoretical underpinnings of attitudinal loyalty treat attitudes as relatively stable and enduring over time (e.g., Ajzen, 1985; Fishbein & Ajzen, 1974); however, considerable research has shown that attitudes can actually be quite malleable (Kawakami et al., 2003; Ledgerwood & Chaiken, 2007) and susceptible to change based on counterattitudinal information and events (Albarracin & Shavitt, 2018; Dibbets et al., 2012). This is pertinent in the context of the current study, as the focus is on identity conflict stemming from events that run counter to one's fan identity.

Behavioral loyalty has been conceptualized differently depending on the study. Mahmoudian et al. (2021) define behavioral loyalty as past behavior or future behavioral intentions (e.g., attendance, watching, or purchase intention). Elsewhere, the notion of behavioral intentions has been conceptualized as conative loyalty, which is the third stage in the four-stage model discussed previously, but captures the intent to perform a behavior. Yoshida et al. (2015) include a behavioral intention construct in their model, measuring actual in-season attendance behavior in a longitudinal fashion as the ultimate behavioral outcome. Therefore, in the absence of data on individuals' actual behavior, it seems an indication of their past behavior and/or intention for future behavior makes for a good proxy. The nature of this behavior as it pertains to sport entities, such as teams, athletes, and/or leagues, could refer to attending games, watching on television, purchasing, and wearing officially licensed team and/or player merchandise, and so on.

While the two dimensions of loyalty are conceptually distinct, they are also inherently related. Indeed, there is a long-held belief that behavior follows from attitudes. Ajzen's (1985) theory of planned behavior, for example, posits that one's attitudes, in conjunction with subjective norms and perceived ability to perform a given behavior, would predict their intention to perform that behavior and, ultimately, the behavior itself. Support has been found for this model in the sporting domain, with attitudes and norms accounting for the most variance in intention to attend a hockey game (Cunningham & Kwon, 2003).

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

On the other hand, evidence of individuals behaving in ways that run counter to their attitudes has also been found (Yuan et al., 2023). Theorists have shown that the consistency of the relationship between attitudes and behavior depends on the context in which those attitudes were formed. Attitudes formed through direct behavior with an attitude object (e.g., consumer brand, sport team, etc.) demonstrate significantly stronger attitude-behavior consistency than those formed through other avenues. Addressing the notion of counterattitudinal events and information, Gawronski et al. (2014) showed that changes in evaluations of an object can be specific only to the context in which the counterattitudinal information was learned. Thus, although consumer studies have regularly found empirical evidence of the strong link between attitudinal and behavioral loyalty (Dick & Basu, 1994; Mandhachitara & Poolthong, 2011; Saini & Singh, 2020), it is possible that counterattitudinal information, such as athlete activism that runs counter to one's own political beliefs, may affect attitudes toward the athlete, but not their sport consumption behavior; Gawronski et al. (2014), negative attitudes may be limited only to when the athlete is engaging in off-field activism and may not spill over to game situations.

Loyalty at either stage—whether attitudinal or behavioral—is associated with a host of desirable outcomes, including greater sales and profits (Tsiotsou, 2013), reduced price sensitivity (Bae et al., 2021), and favorable word-of-mouth (Casidy & Wymer, 2015). As a result, it is a commonly studied outcome in both the aforementioned academic studies and industry research (e.g., Plunkett Research, 2013; PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011). Many studies focusing on sport teams have found team identification to serve as a primary driver of fan loyalty (Karjaluoto et al., 2016; Wu et al., 2012). However, given the dearth of research in this area and limitations in previous studies, it is unclear how political identity conflict might impact loyalty. Nevertheless, two theoretical perspectives commonly used to study sport fandom could offer a framework through which to examine this phenomenon.

Theoretical Framework

In 2007, sport marketing scholars Heere and James theorized that external group identities—whether based on demographic categories, social roles, or organizations to which an individual perceives membership can serve to strengthen one's identification with a sport team to the extent that they are perceived as *congruent* with that team. Among the external group identities discussed in this work is a fan's political identity. Illustrating the overlap between sport and political identities, the scholars reviewed a series of examples in which sport was used as a platform to enhance a national identity and/or promote nationalistic ideology or superiority. As noted by Heere and James (2007), when a consumer perceives a team as a strong fit with one or more external identities, their identification with and loyalty to that team will be strengthened. While their work did not focus on situations where the external identity is *not* perceived as congruent with the team identity, logic would suggest that there is a possibility the opposite would occur. That is, loyalty toward the team would be weakened.

There is a theoretical precedent for such a notion. In his work on balance theory, Heider (1957) postulates that people have an innate drive to maintain balance between attitudes and behaviors. If there is an inconsistency somewhere, the person is motivated to change their attitudes and/or behaviors toward one entity or another. For example, a classic study on celebrity endorsements showed that if a consumer is favorable toward a celebrity and perceives that the celebrity is favorable toward a product, the consumer will become more favorable toward the product as a result (Mowen & Brown, 1981). This pattern is consistent with Heere and James's (2007) work on external group identities; however, Mowen and Brown's (1981) work also showed that the opposite is true. That is, if a person has a preconceived unfavorability toward the product being endorsed, which may, in turn, compromise their liking of the celebrity due to the drive to maintain balance. In short, the individual would need to change their attitudes toward one entity or the other to restore balance.

In the context of the current study, the root of the imbalance would be a conflict between political and fan identities. Per Karelaia and Guillén (2014) identity conflict occurs when individuals perceive dissonance between meanings of two or more identities. This dissonance, or conflict as it may be called, is, in turn, difficult to manage. Consistent with balance theory (Heider, 1957), the individual may feel some level of internal pressure to alter their feelings toward one identity or the other as a means of restoring balance. In this case, it begs the question if loyalty toward a sport entity may be eroded due to the perceived imbalance, or conflict between political and fan identities. As Heere and James (2007) argued, loyalty is heightened when identities are congruent, so it would seem theoretically possible that the opposite may be true if incongruent or in conflict. However, as previously noted, to this point the literature is unclear on this phenomenon. Hence, the need for the current research, which aims to explore the following questions:

RQ1: How does political identity conflict affect sport fan loyalty?

RQ2: How do fans manage political identity conflict as it pertains to their sport fandom?

RQ3: Does the role of political identity conflict in sport fandom differ as a function of political orientation?

Study 1

The purpose of Study 1 was to explore the three RQs. Given the relative dearth of research on this phenomenon, as well as the nature of the RQs, the initial investigation of the RQs was conducted in a qualitative manner. While it would be possible to draw some conclusions about the effect of political identity conflict on sport fan loyalty, as well how this differs as a function of political orientation (RQ1 and RQ3, respectively) using quantitative methods, it would seem RQ2 is best explored through qualitative methods. Indeed, this question, in particular, gets to the heart of the human experience of being invested in both sports and politics. Sometimes, those worlds are going to collide and, given that qualitative research serves to "describe human experience as it is lived," (Thompson et al., 1989, p. 136), a qualitative methodology was determined to be the best course of action for initial exploration. Further, initial insights about RQ1 and RQ3 could also be gleaned via a qualitative approach, potentially serving to inform a follow-up study.

Participants and Procedure

Participants were solicited via a screening survey that was created using Qualtrics survey software. Amazon's Mechanical Turk research data collection platform was used to solicit participants for the survey. This survey was brief, made up of questions

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

pertaining to political party affiliation and identification with the party, identification with a sport entity of their choosing, loyalty toward that sport entity, and questions regarding demographic. It also asked participants to describe a situation where their political values and sport fandom were in conflict. Last, it asked them to provide an email address where they could be contacted if they were interested in participating in a follow-up interview and told they would receive $25 Amazon gift card.

The screening survey served two purposes. First, it served as a repository of contacts who fit the profile of the phenomenon under investigation—specifically, that they identify as both a sport fan, and someone who is engaged in politics, and may potentially be interested in participating in an interview. Second, it provided initial data about their political leanings. As noted, one of the RQs aims to get a sense of how political orientation affects political identity conflict and fan loyalty toward sport entities. As such, it was important to interview participants with both conservative and liberal political orientations. The screening survey ensured that participants from both sides could be contacted for participation. In total, 20 interviews were conducted, 10 of which were with participants who identified as Liberal, and 10 with participants who identified as Conservative. In addition, given that the aim of the study was to investigate how political identity conflict impacted fan loyalty, a concerted effort was made to recruit individuals who had experienced high levels of conflict. That is, those who reported high levels were contacted first and recruitment continued in descending order until a sufficient number of interviews had been completed. The interview included a mix of participants of varied gender and age (see Table 1 for a profile of interview participants).

Materials

Before conducting interviews, a two-step process was used to develop the interview guide (see Appendix). First, per McCracken and McCrackens' (1988) theory and literature on identity conflict, politics and sport were used as a means of developing questions to be asked in the interviews. For example, following the notion that individuals feel internal pressure to modify their feelings toward one entity or another when they come into conflict (e.g., Heider, 1957), participants were asked if they ever felt any internal pressure to modify their feelings toward a team, league, or athlete when they said or did something that conflicted with participants' political values. Consistent with the procedure laid out by McCracken and McCracken (1988), other questions were more general in nature, simply asking participants to reflect on their experiences as someone who is engaged in both sport and politics. This allowed them to speak openly about their lived experience, which captures the overarching aim of qualitative research (Rossman & Rallis, 2012). Second, a colleague with expertise in sport consumer behavior examined the interview guide, providing feedback for rephrasing and/or additional questions (see Appendix for the interview guide). While the interview guide served as the basis for the composition

Table 1 Study 1 Participant Profile

Participant	Age	Identity conflict (out of 7)	Political party ID (out of 100)	Political orientation
Liberal participants				
Oliver	35	3	100 (I)	Moderately liberal
Liv	37	6	60 (D)	Very liberal
Steve	40	3.67	50 (D)	Very liberal
Bruce	47	2.67	20 (D)	Moderately liberal
Gary	38	4	60 (D)	Very liberal
Harry	38	5.67	90 (D)	Very liberal
Luther	38	5.33	72 (D)	Very liberal
Victoria	33	4.67	80 (D)	Very liberal
Peg	38	4	60 (D)	Moderately liberal
Nancy	49	4	50 (D)	Moderately liberal
Average	39.3	4.30	64.2	
Conservative participants				
Wilson	41	3.33	60 (I)	Moderately conservative
Lance	69	3	75 (R)	Very conservative
Nathaniel	51	1.67	50 (R)	Moderately conservative
Tori	50	5.67	70 (R)	Moderately conservative
Kevin	46	3.33	25 (R)	Moderately conservative
Mason	33	5	30 (R)	Very conservative
Saul	63	7	100 (R)	Very conservative
Dick	58	4.33	80 (R)	Moderately conservative
Jack	33	3.67	45 (R)	Moderately conservative
Felicia	40	5.33	90 (R)	Very conservative
Average	48.4	4.23	62.5	

Note. Political party affiliation and identification results (on a 100-point scale) were derived from a screening survey. Political orientation was communicated verbally by the participant at the beginning of each interview. D = democratic party; R = republican party; I = independent.

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

of the interviews, an on-going coding method was used, such that ideas raised by participants in interviews could be retained for questioning in subsequent interviews with other participants (Finlay & Gough, 2008).

Interviews were conducted on Zoom video conferencing software between spring of 2023 and spring of 2024. They were recorded for the purposes of creating a written transcript of the interview. On average, the interviews lasted about 45 min. Consistent with Rossman and Rallis's (2012) notion of a member check, time was taken during interviews to review responses with participants to ensure responses were being interpreted correctly. Interviews proceeded until further interviews failed to yield novel insights, which occurred after about 10 interviews for each political orientation.

Analysis

Following each interview, transcripts were created and reviewed by the author. Initial codes were placed next to ideas that pertained directly to the RQs or to those that could indirectly affect participants' experience as it pertains to the RQs. For example, when participants spoke about how the experience of political identity conflict did or did not affect their feelings and/or behavior toward a sport entity, a code was placed next to the response, as this was one of the primary RQs in the study. However, at other times, a number of participants spoke openly about how they did not perceive the words or actions of a sport league as truly authentic when it has to do with politics, feeling instead that this is nothing more than a carefully crafted public relations effort to boost the bottom line. While this does not directly pertain to any of the RQs, it could indirectly affect the intensity of fans' experience of political identity conflict and/or how it impacts their loyalty toward the league. Thus, a code would be placed next to this idea as well.

In general, the codes were data-driven, but it must be stressed that some themes were rooted in relevant theory, such as Heider's (1957) work on internal balance. For example, Questions 4–6 on the interview guide (see Appendix) require participants to recall a time when their political values and sport fandom were in conflict (in other words, they were out of balance) and discuss how this impacted their attitudes and behavior toward the entity. Participants had to remark on whether this changed their attitude or behavior toward one or the other in an effort to restore balance and how they managed this process. In a sense, then, the coding of responses to this question was deductive, with codes based on the balance theory (Heider, 1957) and external group identity (Heere & James, 2007) literature cited previously, which were used to frame these questions in the interview guide. Other themes were a result of more inductive coding, driven by the data itself. For example, participants almost unanimously spoke of a belief that league-driven political advocacy is public relations-driven, as opposed to a truly authentic perspective. This widespread cynicism was not rooted in theory, but rather occurred organically through inductive coding of the interview transcripts. Per Braun et al. (2014), this data- and theory-driven dichotomy in qualitative analysis is common. As noted previously, the analysis and coding took place in an on-going manner as the interviews unfolded. Initially, coding looked only for consistent themes across both conservative and liberal participants. As the process endured and a substantial number of participants were interviewed on both sides, differences between groups were identified and this was incorporated into the coding. This allowed for a holistic set of themes, some that were common across political orientation (i.e., liberal and conservative), and some that encapsulated differences between these two distinct groups.

Results

Commonalities Across Political Orientation

Two themes emerged across participants of all backgrounds, regardless of political orientation. First, there was a pervasive sense of cynicism expressed with regard to league-driven political stances. Second, participants indicated that their attitudinal loyalty was affected by the experience of political identity conflict, but, by and large, behavioral loyalty remained intact. These themes have important implications for the RQs, particularly RQ1.

Cynicism of Organization-Driven Political Stances

As part of the questioning, the interviewer asked participants their perspective on stances sport leagues have taken on political issues. Examples of this might include the NFL's handling of players protesting perceived social injustices by kneeling for the National Anthem or the NBA's use of progressive political messaging on player uniforms during the 2020 playoffs. Across political orientations, participants did not perceive these stances as authentic. Rather, they felt they were public relations (PR) efforts or "PR-washed," as one participant put it. Liv, a very liberal sport fan, stated the following about the NFL's handling of the National Anthem protest:

> I am very cynical when it comes to the NFL. I think Roger Goodell is full of (expletive). I don't think he really cares either way whether Kaepernick or other players kneel. He could've meant what he said about regretting the decision (to ban kneeling), but he also could've been saying it because it's what needs to be said and it's all performative. I literally don't believe a word that comes out of that man's mouth.

Expressing a similar sentiment, Luther stated the following:

> As an organization, like, it is such a business first and, like, is never going to lead the way on anything. Like they're gonna give up any power or influence or security that they have only as a means of a like survival tactic? Or how do we give the least that we can in a package that makes it look like we're actually making progress or care because, like, they're totally going to protect their number one interests first, and, like I have very—I have very skeptical views of them, and very low hopes that they'll ever actually, like, positively drive any form of change.

This was a perspective that was shared across the board by both liberal and conservative fans alike. Wilson, a moderately conservative sport fan, stated the following:

> When you look at the NFL, I think it's, it's fairly clear that what they were doing was following what the polls were telling them. They felt like their base was against the kneeling, so they were against the kneeling, and then, when it became apparent that they were going to be losing fans if they didn't support the kneeling, it was "Oh, I wish I'd supported the players all along." However, I think, on the other side of the coin, the NBA has capitalized on elevating the individual athletes in their League. That's how they've made their money is elevating Jordan, Lebron . . . .

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

This perspective on league-driven political stances is important to note because it seems, perhaps, not all political identity conflicts are created equal. There is a difference, for example, between a league taking a stance and an individual athlete. The athletes' words or actions are perceived as authentic, whereas the leagues' are seen as profit-driven. This perspective is captured by Mason, a very conservative fan, as he argues, "I tend to give athletes the benefit of the doubt because it's human. I go the opposite way at the league level because it's public relations-washed."

Attitudinal Loyalty Is Affected, but Behavioral Loyalty Is Not

As noted in the literature review, fan loyalty can be understood as a two-dimensional construct made up of both an attitudinal and behavioral component. This dichotomy is central to the experience of political identity conflict because it seems to have a pronounced impact on one but not so much the other, and this was the case across political orientations. Indeed, fans' attitudes toward sport entities at the center of their political identity conflict appears to have been negatively affected, but behavioral loyalty, on the other hand, remained intact. Harry, a very liberal sport fan, stated the following:

> It is interesting to cheer for an NFL team and want them to win, and knowing that (Rodgers) gives you the best chance. This Guy's a hall of famer. He's a Super Bowl champion. He's one of the best throwers of the football of all time, you know what I mean? And then, like, knowing that he gives you the best chance ... but also because of just like other comments and opinions he's had that I've differed with him just being, like, I don't want to cheer for him anymore, even though I know he gives the best chance to the team that I cheered—that I legitimately love. You know? I have been a Packers fan since I was a little tiny kid. You know what I mean? And it's like, I do love this team. I love everything about it. And he was always just like, yeah, just like the one I was just getting tired of cheering for, you know?

This comment captures the dichotomy in how loyalty is affected quite clearly. This is a fan who has a great deal of loyalty to the Green Bay Packers and the athletes who play for them. When Aaron Rodgers used his platform to espouse political beliefs that conflict with his own, Harry's feelings toward Rodgers were negatively affected. He continued to watch Rodgers and root for him to perform well due to his affiliation with the Green Bay Packers, his beloved football team, but, in his words, he was "tired" of cheering for him. In short, his attitudinal loyalty was negatively impacted by the experience of political identity conflict, but his behavioral loyalty remained intact.

Conservative sport fans interviewed for this study expressed a similar sentiment. This is captured by the following quote from an interview with Mason:

> If you remember Colin Kaepernick, I thought the right-wing controversy was ridiculous. When the Bills decided to stay in the locker room, I have a lot of friends who are veterans, too. I get it if you want to make a statement. That's valid. But to opt out ... that's a poor route to take. I was disappointed .... It didn't make me want to stop watching, but it did give me a little less affinity toward some of the players.

Wilson, a moderately conservative sport fan, added the following:

> Yeah, I believe it was Tim Thomas. He boycotted Obama, as I recall, it must have been after they won the cup in 2011. Yeah, and I don't remember what his issue even was. He, as I recall, had some ... probably some libertarian kind of leanings. I found myself at odds with him on that. I didn't really take much of an issue, you know, to the place where I wasn't going to follow the Bruins or anything, but it was just kind of annoying. Just take the honor of going to the White House and let it live with whatever the political differences are, you know?

On some level, sport entities can take solace in this finding. Although fans' feelings may be negatively impacted, they are still going to watch.

Differences Between Political Orientations

While the two groups had significant similarities, there were also a number of noteworthy differences. These differences include how the two groups manage political identity conflict, and how they perceive athlete activism, and the infiltration of politics into sport more broadly. These themes have important implications for RQ2 and RQ3.

Liberal Fans Struggle More With Managing Political Identity Conflict

Interview participants were asked to explain how they managed their experience of political identity conflict. They were probed to reflect on whether this was an automatic, naturally occurring process, or more of an automatic one that didn't require much introspection. A dichotomy began to emerge between participants, where liberals touched on a difficult process of making sense of the inner turmoil, and conservatives more or less shrugged it off and continued on in their fan journey. Liv captures the liberal perspective in the following comment:

> I had a period of time pre-pandemic where I truly didn't know if I could watch (the NFL) and watched less. You know, I cared about these issues, and I was doing all this other activism that was—this was probably like the peak of my activism, too—and like speaking out and working with organizations. And I was like, I'm such a principled person. How can I continue to watch this? And I would talk about it and struggle with it and put it on, but put it on less, and just kind of enjoy it less. And I was like I am the biggest hypocrite, like, how can I do this? And that went on for a little while. But I resign myself to the fact that I'm a human who's complicated and filled with inherent contradiction. And I'm just allowing both of those sides to live.

Similarly, Oliver talks through a difficult process of making sense of the conflict:

- Belichick and Brady and those guys, you know, I think at first it was easy to be like "well screw them." You know, you want to like Trump? Screw them. And then you start to realize people in your circle that like Trump, and you're like, "well (expletive) like, am I really going to disown my dad?" Like, it's my dad. You know, like, am I really gonna like quit my job if I'm surrounded by a bunch of Trumpers at work? And you start to think about all these people you have these significant relationships with, and how you're just gonna cut them at the scene because of who they like. You're like, yeah, I don't know if I want to do this.
- This (Brady and Belichick) is someone I've enjoyed seeing on my TV screen every Sunday for 20 years. You know they're

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

> both very good at what they do. Am I gonna stop being a fan of the Patriots because they like this guy? And I think what I kept telling myself is like, in an ultimate worst-case scenario, Trump can only be in office eight years out of my life, and at that point, you know, Tom Brady was the quarterback of the New England patriots for 15 years. Right? Same with Belichick – head coach for 15 years.

Evident in Oliver's thought process is a pervasive effort to rationalize the conflict he was experiencing. This was more than a shrug of the shoulders. Much like Liv, he had to convince himself that it was okay to watch and root for individuals with whom he had such extreme and deep-rooted differences. In both cases, they were able to manage the conflict to where their behavioral loyalty endured, but it was far from a seamless process.

The perspective espoused by conservative participants was much different. They didn't speak to a messy process of working through inner turmoil. Rather, it was a straightforward, automatic, and pragmatic process. Kevin, a 46–year-old moderately conservative NFL fan, sums up this perspective in the following remark:

> I wouldn't say, you know, it ... you know the players probably have these beliefs and you just—you have to accept it if you're going to watch sports in this day and age. With social media, everything, everyone has a platform now. Everyone wants attention. It's just what it is.

For the most part, conservative participants did not have a lot to say about managing the conflict. It was not an active process for them. They essentially just accepted it was part of being a sport fan who is also invested in politics, and let bygones be bygones.

Sports and Politics Should(n't) Coexist

Another point on which liberals and conservatives differed is on politics and its place in sport. For the most part, liberals felt it was impossible to separate the two, whereas conservatives felt, unequivocally, that they should be separate. The liberal perspective is articulated in the following comment from Harry:

> That's like saying politics and business don't mix, or any—you can make any type of correlation with that. And it's just not true. Politics is what affects everyone's life, you know, no matter what business you're in and sports is a business. It's definitely a business. So when these people are working, it's like, I disagree with that wholeheartedly.

Other liberal participants expressed a similar point of view, with many noting they felt that it was not possible to separate the two due to the human element of sport and politics.

> Steve: There doesn't *need* to be politics in sports. Like you engage with sports for the sporting nature of it, and to watch the competition, and cheer for a team or a player, and see the outcome, and be happy or sad, or whatever. But the reality for me is that these are all people, and so they do things or say things or whatever. So you can't just remove that from the situation.
>
> Liv: I think when people on the right say (sport and politics don't mix), I think it's a way for them to silence people they disagree with ... . I do get fans who like kind of want to escape, but it's ludicrous to expect these humans to separate who they are as a person from their sport.

Conservatives, on the other hand, were largely explicit in their belief that the two should be separated. For example, Lance, a very conservative sport fan, stated, "Politics is life and sports is entertainment and when you try to bring politics into sports, I think you kill the product because it's no longer entertainment. It becomes life." Saul, another very conservative sport fan, espoused a similar perspective:

> Well, I think it's like they say, government and religion. I don't think sport has any place with politics or public opinion. Sports is sports. You know, like religion is religion. Keep it in church. You want to talk about it at home, have your groups, that's fine. But, you know, don't go into sports and talk about it.

By and large, this was the prevailing sentiment among conservative participants. They prefer their sport be separate from politics.

Athletes Should(n't) Use Their Platform for Political Advocacy

A nuance of the idea of sports and politics intersecting is athlete activism. Liberal and conservative sport fans were largely divided on this issue. The liberal perspective is captured in the following statement from Oliver:

> They have this big (expletive) platform and they're finally using it for a purpose, for a cause. And whether you agree with why they're doing it, that shouldn't be what the focus is. The focus is they are doing more than just being a professional athlete.

Alternatively, conservatives indicated that their problem was not so much the activism, but the fact that the activism was coming from a place of ignorance. They did not believe the athlete activists were educated on the issues to where they should be looked at as an authority. In that sense, their issue was with the societal phenomenon of looking to athletes and entertainers as experts on matters of public concern. Nathaniel, a moderately conservative sport fan, captures this sentiment in the following quote:

> When you have athletes sort of grandstanding, and using their platform to talk about things they really don't know about, that's what is kind of disconcerting for me. It's not the fact that they're saying it, but they're often speaking from a place of ignorance, and in a way that's inflammatory, and often a form of demagoguery.

On the liberal side, Luther expressed a similar perspective and, while the majority of liberal participants unequivocally supported athlete activism, Luther conceded merit in the conservative perspective. This is captured in the following sequence:

> I would say, like, by and large, most of the activism that I've seen in sports I think has been helpful in, like, pushing for better pay for female athletes, and advocating for the release of Brittany Griner and, like, advocating for reinstatement of Colin Kaepernick and standing with him, and like all these things. Like, all of these things are, in my mind, like things that we should be advocating for. And I guess maybe that's, like, the nature of being a politically progressive sports fan.
>
> It's hard to figure out how we fix, like, a larger societal issue of what we expect of our athletes. But, like, I do think that there is like this societal responsibility to say, like, that's a 22-year-old kid who didn't have a normal childhood because they were a five-star recruit from the time they were 11. Like, let's cut this

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

> person some slack. If they say something dumb, let's like, publicly correct some of this misinformation. We don't need kids thinking that Kyrie Irving is like telling the truth about a lot of stuff. But let's also not like demonize him and act like he's like the worst person in the world. Like, Kyrie didn't get a chance to live the life that I lived and learn different things that I learned. Like, I probably said (expletive) as dumb as Kyrie when I was 13, and like we have trapped Kyrie in like a 13 year old's political world view, because we've made him focus on being a ball player, not a fully-fleshed out human being.

Luther acknowledges that athletes may not always be informed on the issue, but also blames societal expectations and the pressures put on athletically gifted individuals. Thus, while there was *some* overlap when examining quotations from participants, such as Nathaniel, and Luther, the two sides are largely divided on this issue. Liberals believe fully in athletes using their platform for political advocacy and conservatives feel, generally, that this should not happen.

Study 2

Among the findings from Study 1 was that political identity conflict appeared to negatively affect attitudinal loyalty among the group of participants, but behavioral loyalty endured. This was consistent across both liberal and conservative participants. The purpose of the second study was to triangulate these findings by testing the following hypotheses:

> H1: The relationship between Political Identity Conflict and Attitudinal Loyalty will be negative and significant.
>
> H2: The relationship between Political Identity Conflict and Behavioral Loyalty will not be significant.
>
> H3: The relationship between Political Identity Conflict and Attitudinal Loyalty and Behavioral Loyalty will not be dependent on Political Orientation. That is, the interaction effect between Political Identity Conflict and Political Orientation on (a) Attitudinal Loyalty and (b) Behavioral Loyalty will not be significant.

Broadly speaking, triangulation refers to the use of multiple methods for the purpose of promoting greater understanding of a given phenomena (Turner et al., 2017). Mixed-method work often features the use of quantitative methods to supplement qualitative work, and while this is sometimes for the purpose of extending or elaborating on the findings, it can also serve the purpose of triangulation. Indeed, as Gibson (2017) advised, triangulation allows for enhanced confidence in findings. The triangulation of findings provides greater certainty that the results were not a product of a particular method, or data source, and are more likely to be generalizable across studies and populations. The current study aims to determine the generalizability of the notion that political identity conflict among sport fans significantly affects attitudinal loyalty across both liberal and conservative sport fans, but does not significantly impact behavioral loyalty.

A total of 250 participants (18 years old and above) were recruited from the Prolific research data collection platform to complete a survey built using Qualtrics survey software (Qualtrics, LLC). A link to the survey was posted to Prolific, accompanied by a message designed to attract individuals interested in both politics and sport. Interested individuals who met the criteria clicked on the link on Prolific, which redirected them to Qualtrics. Once finished, they returned to Prolific to input the validation code assigned to them at the conclusion of the survey. They were paid $0.75 for their participation.

The survey was made up of questions pertaining to participants' experience of political identity conflict as a sport fan, their level of identification with a sport entity of their choosing, their attitudinal and behavioral loyalty toward that entity, their political orientation, and demographic questions. Questions making up the variables in the study were assessed on a 7-point Likert scale. Initially, the survey asked them to identify a time when their political beliefs and the words and/or actions of a favorite sport team, athlete, or league were at odds with, or, in conflict with one another. It then asked them to briefly describe the situation in about one sentence. They subsequently responded to the identification, identity conflict, and loyalty items in relation to that entity. Two preemptive steps were taken to guard against common methods variance. The response format for Political Orientation and Identification items was different from the response format for those making up the Political Identity Conflict and Loyalty measures. Second, the order of the items was scrambled.

Measures

Political Identity Conflict

To measure political identity conflict, Mansfield et al.'s (2022) scale was used and adapted to the political context. The adapted scale included such items as "I feel torn between being a sports fan and my political interests." The scale exhibited strong psychometric properties in Mansfield et al.'s (2022) work, with a construct reliability of 0.89 and an average variance extracted (AVE) score of 0.68.

Identification

Identification with the sport entity of the participant's choosing was measured using the sport spectator identification scale (e.g., James et al., 2019). Items were adapted to accommodate the flexibility that participants may choose a team, athlete, or league to address the items. For example, a sample item read, "How important is it to you that the (team/athlete/league) is successful?"

Political Orientation

Political orientation was measured using a single-item measure reading simply, "How would you describe your political orientation?" The scale was anchored by 1 = *Very Conservative* and 7 = *Very Liberal*. The choice to measure this using a single item was made because, in recent years, political orientation has become far less nuanced and unambiguous, and thus, per Allen et al. (2022), more easily captured using a single measure. Indeed, Kroh (2007) argued that voters increasingly use general heuristics, such as the right-left dichotomy to orient themselves, as opposed to orienting themselves in a more nuanced fashion based on particular issues. If someone were to be asked about their political orientation, a response of "liberal" or "conservative" is a likely response, and this was consistent when conducting the interviews in Study 1. Therefore, in aggregate, the notion of political orientation is unidimensional, clearly defined, and narrow in scope, and this is precisely when single-item measures are deemed acceptable (Fuchs & Diamantopoulos, 2009).

Attitudinal and Behavioral Loyalty

Loyalty was measured using the psychological commitment and behavioral loyalty scales leveraged in Mahmoudian et al.'s (2021) work.

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

Attention Check

As noted previously, the first question on the survey asked participants to identify a situation where their political beliefs and the words and/or actions of a favored team, athlete, or league were at odds with one another. This question served two primary purposes. First, the questions pertaining to political identity conflict, identification, and loyalty were answered in relation to the entity at the center of the situation participants identified. They could not adequately answer the questions if they did not first identify an appropriate entity. A total of 29 participants failed to adequately do so, thus rendering their response meaningless. They were removed from the study. This was the second primary purpose of placing this question at the beginning of the survey; it served as a validity check. An additional six participants were removed because they did not correctly answer the authentication question, which simply asked that they select "Neutral" for a question inconspicuously placed in the middle of the survey. This resulted in a final sample of 215 participants.

Sample Demographics

The sample consisted of 59% males and 41% females who, on average, were 39.4 years of age. The sample was 80% White, with 10% identifying as Asian/Pacific Islander. The remainder of the sample was made up of individuals identifying as either Black/African American, Hispanic/Latino, Native American, or other.

Analysis and Results

Analysis

The viability of the measures was assessed initially using commonly established metrics, such as Cronbach's alpha, as well as establishing the presence of convergent and discriminant validity. All variables cleared the 0.70 benchmark for Cronbach's alpha recommended by Nunnally (1978). Further, convergent validity was established with all AVE values exceeding the 0.50 cutoff prescribed by Fornell and Larcker (1981) (see Table 2 for descriptive statistics and psychometric properties of the subscales). Finally, discriminant validity was borderline. Fornell and Larcker (1981) argue that all AVE values must exceed the squared correlations between variables for evidence of discriminant validity. However, more commonly, scholars have generally declared discriminant validity in situations with sufficient construct reliability and correlations below .80 (Rönkkö & Cho, 2022), a criteria echoed by statisticians such as Kline (2011). Within, Rönkkö and Cho (2022)

Table 2 Descriptive Statistics and Psychometrics

Items	Mean	*SD*	β	α	AVE
Political identity conflict	2.67	1.50		.883	0.72
I sometimes feel torn between being a fan of my favorite (team, athlete, or league) and my political interests			0.774		
My engagement in politics sometimes comes at the expense of my fandom for my favorite (team, athlete, or league) more than I'd like			0.899		
My interest in politics sometimes affects the quality of my fandom for my favorite (team, athlete, or league)			0.868		
Identification	4.64	1.43		.923	0.66
How important is it to you that the (team/athlete/league) is successful?			0.780		
How strongly do you see yourself as a fan of the (team/athlete/league)?			0.939		
How strongly do your friends see you as a fan of the (team/athlete/league)?			0.917		
During the season, how closely do you follow the (team/athlete/league) via any of the following: In person or on television, the radio, on television news or a newspaper, or the internet?			0.880		
How important is being a fan of the (team/athlete/league) to you?			0.902		
How much do you dislike the (team's/ athlete's/league's) greatest rivals?			0.536		
How often do you display the (team's/ athlete's/league's) name or insignia at your place of work, where you live or on your clothing?			0.617		
Attitudinal loyalty	4.72	1.39		.877	0.53
I will not change my affiliation from my favorite (team, athlete, or league) even if my friends try to convince me			0.621		
I will not change my affiliation from my favorite (team, athlete, or league) in the future even if they are not successful anymore			0.627		
I am very committed to my favorite (team, athlete, or league)			0.924		
I am a real fan of my favorite (team, athlete, or league)			0.886		
There is nothing that could change my commitment to my favorite (team, athlete, or league)			0.601		
I would defend my favorite (team, athlete, or league) in public even if this causes me problems			0.617		
Behavioral loyalty	4.48	1.54		.818	0.52
I have/will often attend games of my favorite (team/athlete/league) live in the stadium			0.443		
I have/will often watch games of my favorite (team/athlete/league) on TV			0.897		
I have/ will often worn/wear the colors/logos of my favorite (team, athlete or league)			0.762		
I have/will purchase a lot of (team/athlete/league)-related merchandise			0.709		
Political orientation	4.53	1.77			
How would you describe your political orientation?					

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

note that some statisticians treat discriminant validity as an either/or phenomenon (e.g., Fornell & Larcker, 1981), but that others have argued that it is a matter of degree, that is, the extent of discriminant validity is a function of correlations between variables relative to their psychometric properties and internal consistency. Rönkkö and Cho's (2022) review of literature indicated that correlations below .80 are rarely considered problematic. Thus, given the strong psychometric properties and all correlations falling below .80, it seems the study meets sufficient criteria for discriminant validity (see Table 3 for the correlations among latent variables).

Hypothesis Testing

To assess the primary hypothesis, a multivariate multiple regression analysis was performed on IBM SPSS Statistics (version 28). In the first step, Attitudinal Loyalty and Behavioral Loyalty were entered as the dependent variables, and Political Identity Conflict, Identification, and Political Orientation were entered as predictor variables. Results of the regressions indicated that the relationship between Political Identity Conflict and Attitudinal Loyalty was negative and significant ($\beta = -0.205$, $p < .001$ [−0.276, −0.133]), offering support for H1. Identification also had a positive and significant relationship with Attitudinal Loyalty ($\beta = 0.775$, $p < .001$ [0.700, 0.805]), but Political Orientation did not ($\beta = 0.024$, $p = .443$ [−0.037, 0.085]). The relationship between Political Identity Conflict and Behavioral Loyalty was not significant ($\beta = 0.015$, $p = .738$ [−0.074, 0.105]), offering support for H2. The relationship between Identification and Behavioral Loyalty was positive and significant ($\beta = 0.824$, $p < .001$ [0.731, 0.918]), while the relationship between Political Orientation and Behavioral Loyalty was not significant ($\beta = 0.021$, $p = .578$ [−0.054, .097]).

In the second step, interaction terms between Political Identity Conflict and Political Orientation as well as Identification, and Political Orientation were added to the model. The relationship between Political Identity Conflict and Attitudinal Loyalty ($\beta = -0.205$, $p = .014$ [−0.367, −0.042]), and Identification and Attitudinal Loyalty ($\beta = 0.741$, $p < .001$ [0.618, 0.865]) remained consistent. Further, the interaction between Political Identity Conflict and Political Orientation on Attitudinal Loyalty was not significant ($\beta = 0.000$, $p = .989$ [−0.032, 0.033]), offering support for H3a. The interaction between Identification and Political Orientation was also not significant ($\beta = 0.007$, $p = .512$ [−0.015, 0.029]). The relationship between Political Identity Conflict and Behavioral Loyalty ($\beta = -0.005$, $p = .962$ [−0.208, 0.198]) as well as Identification and Behavioral Loyalty ($\beta = 0.808$, $p < .001$ [0.654, 0.963]) remained consistent. Furthermore, in support of H3b, the interaction between Political Identity Conflict and Political Orientation on Behavioral Loyalty was not significant ($\beta = 0.005$, $p = .824$ [−0.036, 0.045]). The interaction between Identification and Political Orientation on Behavioral Loyalty was also not significant ($\beta = 0.003$, $p = .807$ [−0.024, 0.031]). In sum, the results serve to triangulate one of the primary findings from Study 1—political identity conflict negatively affects attitudinal loyalty but not behavioral loyalty to sport entities, which is consistent across liberal and conservative fans alike.

Table 3 Correlations Among Latent Variables

	1	2	3	4	5
1. Political identity conflict	1				
2. Identification	.013	1			
3. Attitudinal loyalty	−.220*	.794**	1		
4. Behavioral loyalty	.029	.768**	.731**	1	
5. Political orientation	−.143*	−.066	.007	−.022	1

*Significant at $p < .05$. **Significant at $p < .001$.

In an effort to ensure the results of the study were not inflated by common methods variance, the marker variable technique was employed (e.g., Lindell & Whitney, 2001). The marker variable technique calls for the measurement of correlations between the focal variables in the study and a marker variable (i.e., a variable that is theoretically unrelated to the other variables). Age was chosen as the marker variable in this study. Aside from the correlation between age and political orientation ($r = -.297$, $p < .001$), which one would expect to be significant given the long-standing relationship between age and political values (Desilver, 2014), none of the correlations were significant. This provides an indication that the results were not inflated due to common methods variance.

Finally, due to the relatively high correlations between fan identification, attitudinal loyalty, and behavioral loyalty, the variance inflation factors were measured for the independent variables in the study. This step is common in instances where multicollinearity may be expected to adversely affect the results of a regression. The variance inflation factors ranged from 1.004 to 1.028, which was well below the commonly held 5.0 cutoff to provide confidence that the results were not adversely impacted by multicollinearity (Marcoulides & Raykov, 2019).

Discussion

Across two studies, the current work offers foundational insights on how sport fans experience and manage political identity conflict, and how this impacts their loyalty to sport entities. Semistructured interviews with fans indicated that political identity conflict negatively impacts attitudinal loyalty to fans, but did not significantly alter their behavior. This pattern of results was further supported by the quantitative data collected on a larger group of sport consumers in Study 2. That political identity conflict negatively affected attitudinal loyalty for participants is in line with a stream of research showing that attitudes are malleable and subject to change based on counterattitudinal events (Albarracin & Shavitt, 2018; Dibbets et al., 2012; Kawakami et al., 2003; Ledgerwood & Chaiken, 2007). However, given the long-standing body of research showing consistency between attitudes and behavior (Ajzen, 1985; Fishbein & Ajzen, 1974), as well as attitudinal and behavioral loyalty (Dick & Basu, 1994; Mandhachitara & Poolthong, 2011; Saini & Singh, 2020), it is worth unpacking why the participants in this study may have reported a negative impact of political identity conflict on their attitudes (and attitudinal loyalty) toward a sport entity, but not behavior (and behavioral loyalty).

One possibility is rooted in Ajzen's (1985) theory of planned behavior. While attitudes are one explanatory variable in an individual's behavior, Ajzen argues that they are also impacted by subjective norms and perceived behavioral control. In other words, subjective norms and perceived behavioral control will both affect the predictive power of attitudes on behavior. Most relevant in this context is the role of subjective norms, which are defined as an individual's perception of social pressures to engage or not engage in a given behavior. Consider the following passage from Liv, an interview participant in Study 1:

> I love watching football. It's so fun to watch the game, but it's also all the peripheral stuff to the game, too—like it's such a

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

> social thing I love talking to people about. You know, going out and watching it with friends . . . like all those sort(s) of adjacent stuff, like, that's part of it, too. I really enjoy watching, but I really enjoy what watching allows me to do in a social way. Especially with football . . . there's literally pictures of me when I was a baby, like, in Bronco's gear. It's so just, like, ingrained . . . . It would be sad (not to) be able to participate in that part of our culture.

Watching football plays a big role in the relationships Liv has with family and friends. It is a big part of her "culture," as she puts it. Giving up the act of watching football means giving up a significant part of the culture that defines her social network. In that sense, there could be some level of social pressure (even if only internally) to continue consuming the product in spite of the formation of negative attitudes.

Another potential explanation lies in the notion of contextualized attitudes. As Gawronski et al. (2014) explained, while counterattitudinal information may impact evaluations of a focal object within the context that this information was learned, previously held attitudes toward that object may continue to affect evaluations in other contexts. Thus, for example, if a fan were to witness an athlete espousing political beliefs that run counter to their own in a podcast interview, this information may influence attitudes toward the athlete in contexts, such as off-field interviews, but not impact their attitudes toward the athlete when they are watching that athlete play their sport. Positive evaluations and congruent behavior would endure in this case. In the context of this study, then, when a participant is asked to explain a situation wherein political identity conflict occurred, the negative contextualized attitude stemming from that event is activated. Behavior toward that sport entity endures, however, because that negative attitude is context-dependent.

Regardless, this finding provides an extension of balance theory (Heider, 1957) and Heere and James's (2007) work on external group identities—two widely-used frameworks in sport consumer research. The findings of the current research suggest that, indeed, the attitudes of sport consumers are altered in the face of an imbalance between political values and their fandom of a sport team, athlete, or league. This is a direct extension of the tenets of balance theory and also provides evidence of an inverse of the ideas put forth in Heere and James's (2007) work. While their work delves deep into the strengthening of team identification and loyalty when a relevant external identity is congruent, the current research shows the opposite is also true—(attitudinal) loyalty is weakened when a relevant external identity (in this case political) is incongruent. This advances the literature on external group identities in a sport consumer context.

Significant differences were exhibited by fans based on political orientation. Fans with a liberal belief set expressed a more difficult time managing political identity conflict. For these individuals, it was an active process of self-reflection wherein they worked through the inner turmoil. For conservatives, this was not the case. It was a more automatic process that did not require much in the way of cognitive or affective resources to address. This is interesting given Thorson and Serazio's (2018) finding that conservative fans are more likely to bristle at the perceived intrusion of politics into sport. It seems that, for conservative fans in this study, their primary issue was athletes engaging in activism for progressive causes. Indeed, while they do not appreciate such activities and believe they have no place in sport, it happens with enough regularity that they seem to accept it and move on reasonably quick. Liberal fans, on the other hand, feel politics have a rightful place within sport. They embrace what conservatives consider an intrusion, but it seems to cause them to reflect on whether they are compromising on their principles by continuing to consume the sport or athlete(s) at the source of the conflict. Thus, a process of self-reflection and inner dialogue ensues that tends to result in enduring consumption.

Not all political identity conflicts are created equal. While both sides seemed to be able to recognize the human element at the core of athlete activism, there was deep-rooted cynicism expressed toward sport leagues taking political stances. Participants in the study saw league-driven political advocacy as public relations attempts with the bottom line in mind. Thus, whether they agree with the stance being taken is almost irrelevant, they do not perceive it as an earnest reflection of their political position and behavioral loyalty endures.

Theoretical Implications

First and foremost, the current study represents the first to holistically explore political identity conflict in a sport context. Past studies have looked into specific contexts where political identity conflict might occur, such as Colin Kaepernick's protest of social and economic injustices experienced by people of color (e.g., Eschmann et al., 2021; Kim et al., 2020), or an athlete expressing support, or lack thereof, for a U.S. president (Mudrick et al., 2019); but these studies were more limited in scope and did not fully ground their work in the identity conflict construct. Further, they did not address the impact of the conflict on fans' attitudes and behavior. The current study thus represents an advancement on the existing work in this area by holistically exploring how political identity conflict experienced by sport fans in myriad ways impacts their attitudes and behavior toward sport entities. In doing so, this work serves to extend Heider's (1957) balance theory and Heere and James's (2007) work on external identities in a spectator sport context.

This work also extends literature on loyalty within a sport fandom context. Traditionally, behavioral loyalty has been understood as a direct result of attitudinal loyalty, with the enduring attitudes developed by a sport fan toward a sport entity serving as a compass for their behavior (Funk & James, 2001; Heere & Dickson, 2008). The current work shows that this may not always be the case. Indeed, consistent with a growing body of literature (Albarracin & Shavitt, 2018; Dibbets et al., 2012; Kawakami et al., 2003; Ledgerwood & Chaiken, 2007), attitudes were malleable and subject to change based on counterattitudinal events for this sample of participants, even if behavioral loyalty proved more enduring. This inconsistency between attitudes and behavior could be a result of factors, such as subjective norms interacting with attitudes (Ajzen, 1985), or attitudes being context-dependent (Gawronski et al., 2014; Yuan et al., 2023).

The current study is the first to provide insight on fans' efforts to manage political identity conflict. Results from Study 1 suggest that liberal sport fans struggle with this process more so than conservative fans. This is one of many differences between liberal and conservative fans. To that end, this work adds to the body of literature exploring differences between sport fans based on political orientation. Past work found conservative sport fans to be less tolerant of the intrusion of politics into sport (Thorson & Serazio, 2018). The current study adds further support for this notion.

Finally, the current study answers Funk et al.'s (2016) call for more mixed-method work in the area of sport consumer behavior. The scholars bemoaned the reliance on individual methods, such as attitudinal surveys, to understand the psychology and behavior

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

of sport consumers. They lobbied for scholars to conduct multiple studies to validate findings. By conducting the survey in Study 2, the current work was able to provide a measure of validation for a finding from Study 1, adding further credence for the contribution of the study.

Practical Contributions

In addition to theoretical contributions, this study also comes with insights for practice. Organizations are feeling increased pressure to take political stances (Zahn, 2022), but, as evidenced by examples, such as the backlash felt by Bud Light following their use of a transgender influencer for a promotion, this can come with considerable risk. Thus, there is a need for guidance on navigating the turbulence of the current political climate. On one hand, this study suggests that sport organizations can feel reasonably confident that behavioral loyalty will remain intact regardless of the stance they take. Sport may represent something of an exception in this area. While it is reasonably easy to simply switch to a different beer brand, fans possess a much deeper relationship with their favorite athlete(s), team(s), and sport(s), and switching is not so straightforward. Thus, while attitudes may be compromised, the bottom line does not appear to be in jeopardy.

Second, the differences between liberals and conservatives that were exhibited in this study should prove helpful as sport organizations engage in market segmentation and target marketing. As Jost (2017) explained, liberals and conservatives differ with respect to personality traits, cognitive processing, motivation, values, and neurological structures. Given these differences, political orientation makes for an effective means through which to segment a consumer market (Jost, 2017). The current study adds to this body of literature, offering further insight that could prove helpful to sport marketers looking to target consumers based on their political leanings.

Finally, the fact that both liberals and conservatives alike exhibited cynicism toward league-driven political advocacy suggests leagues may need to come across as more authentic. Consumers' perceptions of authenticity have been shown to impact brand attachment (Thomson, 2006). Thus, leagues would be well served in making efforts to increase fans' perceptions of authenticity. Joo et al. (2019) examined the attributes that make up fans' perceptions of authenticity as it pertains to league's engaging in cause-related marketing. Among other factors, they found that organizations must demonstrate a steadfast commitment to the cause, as opposed to changing initiatives to align with current trends. For many participants, their comments on cynicism were in relation to the NFL and their inconsistent stance on player protests —at one point condemning the activism, while later on expressing support. This suggests that the NFL and other leagues would be better served making a clear decision on their core values and remaining steadfast in spite of societal trends.

Limitations

Despite the contributions of the study, it also comes with limitations. First, data collections in both Study 1 and Study 2 were based on a convenience sample obtained via Amazon's Mechanical Turk and Prolific, respectively. The issues with data quality from Amazon's Mechanical Turk are well documented (Webb & Tangney, 2022), though they can be mitigated through the use of data quality checks (Qureshi et al., 2022), such as those implemented in this study. Further, the Mechanical Turk sample was only used as a screening platform to recruit participants for interviews. As a result of the issues with Mechanical Turk, Prolific was used to collect data for Study 2. In a multistudy comparison of popular data collection platforms, including Mechanical Turk, CloudResearch, Prolific, Qualtrics and Dynata. Peer et al. (2022) found only Prolific to consistently provide high-quality data in both studies.

Second, it is possible that response bias affected participants' responses to interview and/or survey questions, with participants offering up desirable responses as opposed to their true feelings. For example, conservative participants in Study 1 explained that they do not like the intersection of politics and sports, but are generally able to look past it and continue consuming their favorite sport(s). This may indeed be the case—and, certainly, it has precedent in past literature (Thorson & Serazio, 2018), but, it may also be a more desirable answer to provide in an interview. It is possible this operated more generally throughout the survey and/or interviews.

Third, the participants in Study 2 reported considerably lower political identity conflict scores than those in Study 1 ($M = 4.27$ in Study 1 compared with $M = 2.67$ in Study 2). Given that the purpose of Study 2 was to provide a degree of triangulation for one of the findings in Study 1, this difference between the two samples must be acknowledged. The relationship between the variables may differ in samples reporting higher levels of conflict on anonymous self-report surveys.

Finally, participants were asked to look back on—and in the case of the interviews, reflect on, political identity conflict they had previously experienced. The majority of examples cited by participants were relatively recent, but some examples date back more than 10 years. It may be difficult to accurately recall emotions and feelings experienced years ago.

Future Research

Given the potential difficulty in recalling feelings and emotions experienced in the past, scholars would be well served in collecting time series data on the political identity conflict of sport fans *as it is experienced*. Whether a longitudinal survey or sequential interviews, the data would provide useful insight on how political identity conflict is experienced and managed in the moment. It is possible that such an approach could yield more vivid insights on the phenomena of interest, particularly as it applies to the process of managing political identity conflict.

In addition, research should be dedicated to further understanding the differences between political identity conflict stemming from athlete activism and league-driven political advocacy. In the current study, it became clear that participants did not view these the same, with athlete activism perceived as human and authentic, and league-driven political advocacy just the opposite. Research dedicated to understanding how political identity conflict rooted in each, and how it impacts loyalty, and behavior would be a welcomed addition to the literature.

Third, scholars would be well served in researching instances where political advocacy by favored sport entities is congruent with a fan's political values. If researchers were to dichotomize sport organizations' political stances and fans' political orientation, there would be four possible combinations (liberal–liberal, liberal–conservative, conservative–liberal, and conservative–conservative). Indeed, two of these four represent alignment between political and fan identities. Drawing from Heere and James's (2007) work on external group identities, one would expect that the alignment of

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

identities would enhance fan identification and loyalty. However, research substantiating this would help to further build literature on external group identities and sport fandom.

Finally, scholars should seek to better understand *why* political identity conflict could impact attitudinal loyalty toward sport entities but not their behavior. In the current study, two plausible explanations were put forth. These include subjective norms negatively affecting the predictive power of attitudes on behavior (e.g., Ajzen, 1985) and attitudes toward objects being context-dependent (Gawronski et al., 2014). Researchers should delve deeper into these ideas in an effort to determine the source of the disconnect in the context of political identity conflict.

Conclusions

Across two studies, the current work provides the first holistic exploration of political identity conflict in a spectator sport context. Results demonstrate that attitudinal loyalty is negatively affected by political identity conflict for both liberals and conservatives alike, but behavioral loyalty is largely unaffected. Liberal sport fans who participated in the qualitative phase of the research engaged in a more active process of managing the inner turmoil presented by the conflict. Consistent with past literature, conservatives were less receptive to the infiltration of politics into sport. Collectively, the findings offer a multitude of directions for further exploration of political identity conflict in a spectator sport context.

References

Agyemang, K.J., Singer, J.N., & Weems, A.J. (2020). 'Agitate! Agitate! Agitate!': Sport as a site for political activism and social change. *Organization, 27*(6), 952–968. https://doi.org/10.1177/1350508420928519

Ajzen, I. (1985). From intentions to actions: A theory of planned behavior. I.J. Kuhl & J. Beckmann (Eds.), *Action control: From cognition to behavior* (pp. 11–39). Springer-Verlag.

Albarracin, D., & Shavitt, S. (2018). Attitudes and attitude change. *Annual Review of Psychology, 69*(1), 299–327. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-psych-122216-011911

Allen, M.S., Iliescu, D., & Greiff, S. (2022). Single item measures in psychological science. *European Journal of Psychological Assessment, 38*(1), 1–5. https://doi.org/10.1027/1015-5759/a000699

Allison, M. (1982). Sport, culture and socialization. *International Review of Sport Sociology, 17*(4), 11–37. https://doi.org/10.1177/101269028201700401

Bae, J.S., Chiu, W., & Nam, S.B. (2021). Sport fans' price sensitivity based on loyalty levels: A case of Korean professional baseball league. *Sustainability, 13*(6), 3361. https://doi.org/10.3390/su13063361

Bailey, J.R., & Phillips, H. (2020, February 17). How do consumers feel when businesses get political? *Harvard Business Review*. https://hbr.org/2020/02/how-do-consumers-feel-when-companies-get-political

Boykoff, J., & Carrington, B. (2020). Sporting dissent: Colin Kaepernick, NFL activism, and media framing contests. *International Review for the Sociology of Sport, 55*(7), 829–849. https://doi.org/10.1177/1012690219861594

Braun, V., Clarke, V., & Terry, G. (2014). Thematic analysis. *Qualitative Research in Clinical and Health Psychology, 24*, 95–114.

Casidy, R., & Wymer, W. (2015). The impact of brand strength on satisfaction, loyalty and WOM: An empirical examination in the higher education sector. *Journal of Brand Management, 22*(2), 117–135. https://doi.org/10.1057/bm.2015.6

Cunningham, G.B., & Kwon, H. (2003). The theory of planned behaviour and intentions to attend a sport event. *Sport Management Review, 6*(2), 127–145. https://doi.org/10.1016/S1441-3523(03)70056-4

Dart, J. (2014). New media, professional sport and political economy. *Journal of Sport and Social Issues, 38*(6), 528–547. https://doi.org/10.1177/0193723512467356

Desilver, D. (2014, July 9). The politics of American generations: How age affects attitudes and voting behavior. *Pew Research Center*. https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2014/07/09/the-politics-of-american-generations-how-age-affects-attitudes-and-voting-behavior/

Dibbets, P., Adolphs, L., Close, I., Herings, A., Kiggen, M., Kinneging, M., Loffler, L., Nijssen, Y., Schulte-Ostermann, M., & Van Schaaik, P. (2012). Reversal of attitude: The influence of counter-attitudinal information. *Journal of Social Sciences, 8*, 390–396.

Dichter, H.L. (2021). The diplomatic turn: The new relationship between sport and politics. *The International Journal of the History of Sport, 38*(2-3), 247–263. https://doi.org/10.1080/09523367.2021.1894135

Dick, A.S., & Basu, K. (1994). Customer loyalty: Toward an integrated conceptual framework. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science, 22*(2), 99–113. https://doi.org/10.1177/0092070394222001

Eschmann, R., Groshek, J., Li, S., Toraif, N., & Thompson, J.G. (2021). Bigger than sports: Identity politics, Colin Kaepernick, and concession making in# BoycottNike. *Computers in Human Behavior, 114*, 106583. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2020.106583

Evans, A.B., Agergaard, S., Campbell, P.I., Hylton, K., & Lenneis, V. (2020). 'Black Lives Matter': Sport, race and ethnicity in challenging times. *European Journal for Sport and Society, 17*(4), 289–300. https://doi.org/10.1080/16138171.2020.1833499

Finlay, L., & Gough, B. (Eds.). (2008). *Reflexivity: A practical guide for researchers in health and social sciences*. John Wiley & Sons.

Fishbein, M., & Ajzen, I. (1974). Attitudes towards objects as predictors of single and multiple behavioral criteria. *Psychological Review, 81*(1), 59–74. https://doi.org/10.1037/h0035872

Fornell, C., & Larcker, D. (1981). Evaluating structural equation models with unobservable variables and measurement error. *Journal of Marketing Research, 18*,(1) 39–50. https://doi.org/10.1177/002224378101800104

Fuchs, C., & Diamantopoulos, A. (2009). Using single-item measures for construct measurement in management research: Conceptual issues and application guidelines. *The Business Administration, 69*, 195–210.

Fujak, H., Frawley, S., McDonald, H., & Bush, S. (2018). Are sport consumers unique? Consumer behavior within crowded sport markets. *Journal of Sport Management, 32*(4), 362–375. https://doi.org/10.1123/jsm.2017-0318

Funk, D., Lock, D., Karg, A., & Pritchard, M. (2016). Sport consumer behavior research: Improving our game. *Journal of Sport Management, 30*(2), 113–116. https://doi.org/10.1123/jsm.2016-0028

Funk, D.C., & James, J. (2001). The psychological continuum model: A conceptual framework for understanding an individual's psychological connection to sport. *Sport Management Review, 4*(2), 119–150. https://doi.org/10.1016/S1441-3523(01)70072-1

Gawronski, B., Ye, Y., Rydell, R.J., & De Houwer, J. (2014). Formation, representation, and activation of contextualized attitudes. *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 54*, 188–203. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2014.05.010

Gibson, C.B. (2017). Elaboration, generalization, triangulation, and interpretation: On enhancing the value of mixed method research. *Organizational Research Methods, 20*(2), 193–223. https://doi.org/10.1177/1094428116639133

Gift, T., & Miner, A. (2017). "DROPPING THE BALL": The understudied nexus of sports and politics. *World Affairs, 180*(1), 127–161. https://doi.org/10.1177/0043820017715569

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

Golden, M. (1998). *Sport and society in ancient Greece*. Cambridge University Press.

Han, H., Kim, Y., & Kim, E.K. (2011). Cognitive, affective, conative, and action loyalty: Testing the impact of inertia. *International Journal of Hospitality Management, 30*(4), 1008–1019. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijhm.2011.03.006

Haupt, M., Wannow, S., Marquardt, L., Graubner, J.S. and Haas, A. (2023). Who is more responsive to brand activism? The role of consumer-brand identification and political ideology in consumer responses to activist brand messages. *Journal of Product & Brand Management, 32*, 1248–1273.

Heere, B., & Dickson, G. (2008). Measuring attitudinal loyalty: Separating the terms of affective commitment and attitudinal loyalty. *Journal of Sport Management, 22*(2), 227–239. https://doi.org/10.1123/jsm.22.2.227

Heere, B., & James, J.D. (2007). Sports teams and their communities: Examining the influence of external group identities on team identity. *Journal of Sport Management, 21*(3), 319–337. https://doi.org/10.1123/jsm.21.3.319

Heider, F. (1957). *The psychology of interpersonal relations*. John Wiley & Sons.

Hoewe, J., & Hatemi, P.K. (2017). Brand loyalty is influenced by the activation of political orientations. *Media Psychology, 20*(3), 428–449. https://doi.org/10.1080/15213269.2016.1202839

James, J.D., Delia, E.B., & Wann, D.L. (2019). "No" is not "low": Improving the assessment of sport team identification. *Sport Marketing Quarterly, 28*(1), 34–45. https://doi.org/10.32731/smq.281.032019.03

Joo, S., Miller, E.G., & Fink, J.S. (2019). Consumer evaluations of CSR authenticity: Development and validation of a multidimensional CSR authenticity scale. *Journal of Business Research, 98*, 236–249. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2019.01.060

Jost, J.T. (2017). The marketplace of ideology: "Elective affinities" in political psychology and their implications for consumer behavior. *Journal of Consumer Psychology, 27*(4), 502–520. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jcps.2017.07.003

Jung, J., & Mittal, V. (2020). Political identity and the consumer journey: A research review. *Journal of Retailing, 96*(1), 55–73. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretai.2019.09.003

Jung, K., Garbarino, E., Briley, D.A., & Wynhausen, J. (2017). Blue and red voices: Effects of political ideology on consumers' complaining and disputing behavior. *Journal of Consumer Research, 44*(3), 477–499. https://doi.org/10.1093/jcr/ucx037

Karelaia, N., & Guillén, L. (2014). Me, a woman and a leader: Positive social identity and identity conflict. *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 125*(2), 204–219. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.obhdp.2014.08.002

Karjaluoto, H., Munnukka, J., & Salmi, M. (2016). How do brand personality, identification, and relationship length drive loyalty in sports? *Journal of Service Theory and Practice, 26*(1), 50–71. https://doi.org/10.1108/JSTP-09-2014-0206

Kawakami, K., Dovidio, J.F., & Dijksterhuis, A. (2003). Effect of social category priming on personal attitudes. *Psychological Science, 14*(4), 315–319. https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-9280.14451

Kim, J.K., Overton, H., Bhalla, N., & Li, J.Y. (2020). Nike, Colin Kaepernick, and the politicization of sports: Examining perceived organizational motives and public responses. *Public Relations Review, 46*, 1–10.

Kline, R.B. (2011). *Principles and practice of structural equation modeling* (2nd Ed.). Guilford Press.

Kroh, M. (2007). Measuring left–right political orientation: The choice of response format. *Public Opinion Quarterly, 71*(2), 204–220. https://doi.org/10.1093/poq/nfm009

Ledgerwood, A. & Chaiken S. (2007). Priming us and them: Automatic assimilation and contrast in group attitudes. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 93*(6), 940–956. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.93.6.940

Lindell, M.K., & Whitney, D.J. (2001). Accounting for common methods variance in cross-sectional research designs. *Journal of Applied Psychology, 86*(1), 114–121. https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.86.1.114

Long, J., & Hylton, K. (2002). Shades of white: An examination of whiteness in sport. *Leisure Studies, 21*(2), 87–103. https://doi.org/10.1080/02614360210152575

Mahmoudian, A., Sadeghi Boroujerdi, S., Mohammadi, S., Delshab, V., & Pyun, D.Y. (2021). Testing the impact of athlete brand image attributes on fan loyalty. *Journal of Business & Industrial Marketing, 36*(2), 244–255. https://doi.org/10.1108/JBIM-10-2019-0464

Mandhachitara, R., & Poolthong, Y. (2011). A model of customer loyalty and corporate social responsibility. *Journal of Services Marketing, 25*(2), 122–133. https://doi.org/10.1108/08876041111119840

Manoli, A.E. (2024). Strategic brand management in and through sport. *Journal of Strategic Marketing, 32*(6), 814–821.

Mansfield, A.C., Melton, E.N., & Katz, M. (2022). An analysis of identity conflict among health-conscious sport fans. *Journal of Sport Management, 36,*(6) 600–612. https://doi.org/10.1123/jsm.2021-0128

Marcoulides, K.M., & Raykov, T. (2019). Evaluation of variance inflation factors in regression models using latent variable modeling methods. *Educational and Psychological Measurement, 79*(5), 874–882. https://doi.org/10.1177/0013164418817803

McCracken, G.D., & McCracken, G. (1988). *The long interview* (Vol. 13). Sage.

Mowen, J.C., & Brown, S.W. (1981). On explaining and predicting the effectiveness of celebrity endorsers. *Advances in Consumer Research, 8*, 437–441.

Mudrick, M., Sauder, M.H., & Davies, M. (2019). When athletes don't "stick to sports": The relationship between athlete political activism and sport consumer behavior. *Journal of Sport Behavior, 42*, 177–199.

Nunnally, J.C. (1978). An overview of psychological measurement. In B.B. Wolman (Ed.), *Clinical diagnosis of mental disorders: A handbook* (pp. 97–146). Springer.

Peer, E., Rothschild, D., Gordon, A., Evernden, Z., & Damer, E. (2022). Data quality of platforms and panels for online behavioral research. *Behavior Research Methods, 54*(4), 1643–1662. https://doi.org/10.3758/s13428-021-01694-3

Plunkett Research. (2013). *Introduction to the sports industry*. www.plunkettresearch.com/sports-recreation-leisure-market-research/industry-and-business-data

PricewaterhouseCoopers. (2011). Changing the game. Outlook for the global sports market to 2015, research report. *Pwc*. www.pwc.com/en_GX/gx/hospitalityleisure/pdf/changing-the-game-outlook-for-the-global-sports-market-to-2015.pdf

Qureshi, N., Edelen, M., Hilton, L., Rodriguez, A., Hays, R.D., & Herman, P.M. (2022). Comparing data collected on Amazon's Mechanical Turk to national surveys. *American Journal of Health Behavior, 46*(5), 497–502. https://doi.org/10.5993/AJHB.46.5.1

Rönkkö, M., & Cho, E. (2022). An updated guideline for assessing discriminant validity. *Organizational Research Methods, 25*(1), 6–14. https://doi.org/10.1177/1094428120968614

Rossman, G.B., & Rallis, S.F. (2012). *Learning in the field* (3rd ed.). Sage.

Saini, S., & Singh, J. (2020). A link between attitudinal and behavioral loyalty of service customers. *Business Perspectives and Research, 8*(2), 205–215. https://doi.org/10.1177/2278533719887452

Serazio, M., & Thorson, E. (2020). Weaponized patriotism and racial subtext in Kaepernick's aftermath: The anti-politics of American

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

sports fandom. *Television & New Media, 21*(2), 151–168. https://doi.org/10.1177/1527476419879917

Sforza, L. (2023, April 23). NBA champion coach Phil Jackson says he doesn't watch basketball anymore because it got too political. *The Hill*. https://thehill.com/blogs/blog-briefing-room/3965389-nba-champion-coach-phil-jackson-says-he-doesnt-watch-basketball-anymore-because-it-got-too-political/

Smith, A.C., & Stewart, B. (2010). The special features of sport: A critical revisit. *Sport Management Review, 13*(1), 1–13. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.smr.2009.07.002

The Associated Press. (2023, October 31). Bug Light brewer is still reeling from trans promotion backlash as U.S. revenue tumbled 13%. *Fortune*. https://fortune.com/2023/10/31/bud-light-earnings-dylan-mulvaney-transgender-promotion-backlash/

Thompson, C.J., Locander, W.B., & Pollio, H.R. (1989). Putting consumer experience back into consumer research: The philosophy and method of existential-phenomenology. *Journal of Consumer Research, 16,*(2) 133–146. https://doi.org/10.1086/209203

Thomson, M. (2006). Human brands: Investigating antecedents to consumers' strong attachments to celebrities. *Journal of Marketing, 70*(3), 104–119.

Thorson, E.A., & Serazio, M. (2018). Sports fandom and political attitudes. *Public Opinion Quarterly, 82*(2), 391–403. https://doi.org/10.1093/poq/nfy018

Towler, C.C., Crawford, N.N., & Bennett, R.A. (2020). Shut up and play: Black athletes, protest politics, and Black political action. *Perspectives on Politics, 18*(1), 111–127. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1537592719002597

Tsiotsou, R.H. (2013). Investigating the role of enduring and situational involvement with the program context on advertising effectiveness. *Journal of Marketing Communications, 19*(2), 114–135. https://doi.org/10.1080/13527266.2010.542079

Turner, S.F., Cardinal, L.B., & Burton, R.M. (2017). Research design for mixed methods: A triangulation-based framework and roadmap. *Organizational Research Methods, 20*(2), 243–267. https://doi.org/10.1177/1094428115610808

Ulver, S., & Laurell, C. (2020). Political ideology in consumer resistance: Analyzing far-right opposition to multicultural marketing. *Journal of Public Policy & Marketing, 39*(4), 477–493. https://doi.org/10.1177/0743915620947083

Webb, M.A., & Tangney, J.P. (2022). Too good to be true: Bots and bad data from mechanical turk. *Perspectives on Psychological Science, 19*(6), 887–890. https://doi.org/10.1177/17456916221120027

Wu, S.H., Tsai, C.Y.D., & Hung, C.C. (2012). Toward team or player? How trust, vicarious achievement motive, and identification affect fan loyalty. *Journal of Sport Management, 26*(2), 177–191. https://doi.org/10.1123/jsm.26.2.177

Yoshida, M., Heere, B., & Gordon, B. (2015). Predicting behavioral loyalty through community: Why other fans are more important than our own intentions, our satisfaction, and the team itself. *Journal of Sport Management, 29*(3), 318–333. https://doi.org/10.1123/jsm.2013-0306

Yuan, Y., Sun, R., Zuo, J., & Chen, X. (2023). A new explanation for the attitude-behavior inconsistency based on the contextualized attitude. *Behavioral Sciences, 13*(3), 223. https://doi.org/10.3390/bs13030223

Zahn, M. (2022, August 23). Companies increasingly using politics in marketing, but there are risks: Experts. *ABC News*. https://www.whio.com/news/business/companies/6SHPMLNW6AJGFZT4G4ZZSPDG5E/

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC

Appendix: Interview Guide

1. Tell me about yourself.
2. Could you give me a brief history of your interest and engagement in politics, as well as what it looks like currently (e.g., amount of time spent consuming, nature of consumption, etc.)?
3. Could you give me a brief history of your interest and engagement in sport, as well as what it looks like currently (e.g., favorite sports, amount of time spent consuming, nature of consumption, etc.)?
4. Can you recall a time when your politics and sport fandom seemed to be at odds with one another? What was that like?
   a. How did you feel toward the team/player/league?
   b. How did this evolve over time?
   c. How did this impact your ideology/values?
   d. Has your fandom been impacted in any way? If so, how?
5. When a situation such as this occurs, and your feeling toward one or more entities are in conflict, how do you manage that process?
6. Have you ever felt any internal pressure to modify your feelings or behavior toward a team/league/athlete when they say/do something that is at odds with your political values? Why or why not?
7. What about the opposite: That is, have you ever felt any internal pressure to modify your political values to align with those of the team/league/athlete?
8. Have your feelings toward a team/athlete/league ever changed in a positive direction based on their political stances? (e.g., perhaps you disliked a player due to a rivalry, but ended up liking him/her based on their stance on social issues).
9. Has there ever been a time when you had no prior interest in a player, but ended up taking an interest in them because of a political stance they took? Explain.
10. It has often been said, "Sports and politics don't mix." What is your perspective on this statement?
11. Do you think you feel any different about this when the sport and politics intersect in a way that is consistent with your politics?
12. Do you find it possible to avoid/ignore the overlap of sport and politics in this day and age? Explain.
13. In recent years, there has been something of a contrast between the NFL and NBA in terms of the stances they've taken on athlete activism. <Review two stances> How do you perceive the two? How does this affect your feelings and/or behavior toward each?
14. Is there anything else we did not discuss that you think is important to address?

Brought to you by UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE | Unauthenticated | Downloaded 05/19/25 04:13 PM UTC